

WEEK

1

Week 1 Study Guide

Channel Theory: Concept, Nomenclature, Flow of Qi

12 Meridians · 3 Circuits · Foundational Theory

This Document Contains:

What a channel is, and how it differs from a meridian and a collateral
Zang-Fu organ theory and the 12 Primary Meridians' full nomenclature
The Three Circuits (Outer/Anterior, Inner/Posterior, Middle) in full detail
Direction of Qi flow and exactly where paired meridians meet
The full 24-hour Meridian Clock and its clinical application
Dr. Zhang's Clinical Pearls + Quiz 1 Fundamentals

QUIZ 1 covers: Channel Theory (this week's material)

This is the foundation every later week builds on directly
No channel-specific points yet - LU/LI begin next week

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Channels, Meridians, and Collaterals

'Channels' (Jing-Luo) is the umbrella term covering BOTH Meridians (Jing, the primary pathways - like a river) AND Collaterals (Luo, the branches - smaller networks connecting meridians to tissues and organs).

The Full Channel System

- 12 Primary Meridians (Jing) - the main rivers
- 15 Collaterals (Luo) - 12 from each primary meridian's own Luo-connecting point, plus the Luo of Du Mai, Ren Mai, and the Spleen's Great Luo (Dabao)
- 12 Divergent Meridians - branch from the primary meridians, distribute on chest/abdomen/head, deepen the Zang-Fu relationship (detail taught later in the course)
- 12 Muscle (Sinew) Regions - distribution of the primary meridians into the muscular system
- 12 Cutaneous Regions - the most superficial layer, where channel Qi reflects on the skin
- 8 Extraordinary Vessels - Du, Ren, Chong, Dai, Yinwei, Yangwei, Yinqiao, Yangqiao; act as reservoirs of Qi and Blood, closely connected to the Kidney, regulating the primary meridians as needed (detail taught later)

This course's ten weeks build through this system in order: channel theory (this week), the 12 Primary Meridians one by one (Weeks 2-6), additional channels and regions (Week 7), the 8 Extraordinary Vessels (Week 8), and acupuncture points (Week 9). Everything after this week assumes this vocabulary is second nature.

Zang-Fu Organ Theory

Zang (Yin) Organs - 6 total

- Lung (LU)
- Spleen (SP)
- Heart (HT)
- Liver (LR)
- Kidney (KI)
- Pericardium (PC)

Fu (Yang) Organs - 6 total

- Large Intestine (LI)
- Stomach (ST)
- Small Intestine (SI)
- Bladder (BL)
- Gallbladder (GB)
- San Jiao (SJ)

Zang organs are solid/dense and considered Yin. Fu organs are hollow and considered Yang. Each of the 12 Primary Meridians pertains to exactly one of these 12 organs, and connects to its interior-exterior paired organ (its Zang-Fu partner).

The 3-Part Nomenclature System

1. Hand or Foot (location of the pathway)
2. Yin or Yang (nature / medial-lateral surface)
3. Zang or Fu (pertaining organ)

e.g. 'Lung Meridian of Hand-Taiyin', 'Stomach Meridian of Foot-Yangming'

Anterior = Taiyin(yin)/Yangming(yang); Posterior = Shaoyin(yin)/Taiyang(yang); Middle = Jueyin(yin)/Shaoyang(yang) - this naming is based on LOCATION (medial/lateral position on the limb), not organ function.

Full Reference Table

Ab	Name	Classification	Direction	Circuit
LU	Lung	Hand Taiyin	Chest -> Hand	Outer (Anterior)
LI	Large Intestine	Hand Yangming	Hand -> Head	Outer (Anterior)
ST	Stomach	Foot Yangming	Head -> Foot	Outer (Anterior)
SP	Spleen	Foot Taiyin	Foot -> Chest	Outer (Anterior)
HT	Heart	Hand Shaoyin	Chest -> Hand	Inner (Posterior)
SI	Small Intestine	Hand Taiyang	Hand -> Head	Inner (Posterior)
BL	Bladder	Foot Taiyang	Head -> Foot	Inner (Posterior)
KI	Kidney	Foot Shaoyin	Foot -> Chest	Inner (Posterior)
PC	Pericardium	Hand Jueyin	Chest -> Hand	Middle
SJ	San Jiao (Triple Burner)	Hand Shaoyang	Hand -> Head	Middle
GB	Gallbladder	Foot Shaoyang	Head -> Foot	Middle
LR	Liver	Foot Jueyin	Foot -> Chest	Middle

This is the single most important table in this document. Every week from here forward builds on knowing a channel's abbreviation, full classification, direction of flow, and which circuit it belongs to, instantly and without hesitation.

The Three Circuits, in Full

Every one of the 12 Primary Meridians belongs to exactly one of three circuits. Each circuit contains exactly four meridians - one Hand Yin, one Hand Yang, one Foot Yang, and one Foot Yin - following the same repeating pattern: chest to hand, hand to head, head to foot, foot to chest.

Outer Circuit (Anterior)

Taiyin / Yangming

LU (chest->hand) -> LI (hand->head) -> ST (head->foot) -> SP (foot->chest)

Inner Circuit (Posterior)

Shaoyin / Taiyang

HT (chest->hand) -> SI (hand->head) -> BL (head->foot) -> KI (foot->chest)

Middle Circuit (Middle/Lateral)

Jueyin / Shaoyang

PC (chest->hand) -> SJ (hand->head) -> GB (head->foot) -> LR (foot->chest)

A useful way to remember: the Outer Circuit's Yang partner is Yangming (LI, ST); the Inner Circuit's Yang partner is Taiyang (SI, BL); the Middle Circuit's Yang partner is Shaoyang (SJ, GB). Match the location name to the circuit and the rest follows.

Direction of Qi Flow

Yin meridians of the HAND

Yang meridians of the HAND

Yang meridians of the FOOT

Yin meridians of the FOOT

Chest -> Hand

Hand -> Head

Head -> Foot

Foot -> Chest/Abdomen

This four-part rule is the single most repeated fact across every lecture and quiz review in this course. Memorize it as one continuous loop: chest to hand, hand to head, head to foot, foot to chest - and back to chest again, completing the cycle.

Where Paired Meridians Meet

Hand Yin meets Hand Yang, at the FINGERS

e.g. LU7's branch meets LI1 at the index finger

Hand Yang meets Foot Yang, at the FACE

e.g. LI ends at LI20, ST begins there

Foot Yang meets Foot Yin, at the TOES

e.g. ST ends at ST45, SP begins at SP1

Foot Yin meets Hand Yin, at the CHEST

completes the full 12-channel loop back to the next circuit

The Meridian Clock (24-Hour Cycle)

Each meridian has a two-hour period of peak activity, following the same order the meridians connect to each other. Dr. Zhang's own clinical example: to treat a Large Intestine dysfunction, consider its 5-7 AM active window; symptoms that flare at a specific time of day can point directly to which channel is involved.

LU: 3-5 AM

LI: 5-7 AM

ST: 7-9 AM

SP: 9-11 AM

HT: 11 AM-1 PM

SI: 1-3 PM

BL: 3-5 PM

KI: 5-7 PM

PC: 7-9 PM

SJ: 9-11 PM

GB: 11 PM-1 AM

LR: 1-3 AM

The 3 Functions of Meridians

Transporting

Transport Qi and Blood to nourish the organs, skin, muscles, tendons, and bones; keep Yin-Yang in harmony throughout the body.

Resisting (Defending)

Defend the body against disease - meridians help resist pathogens and reflect symptoms/signs when something is wrong.

Treatment

Transmit needling sensation and regulate deficiency and excess conditions - the basis for using meridians and points clinically.

Dr. Zhang's Clinical Pearls — Direct from Lecture

The Meridian Clock Has Real Clinical Use

Dr. Zhang's own example: if you want to treat a Large Intestine dysfunction, consider timing treatment around 5-7 AM, LI's active period. Symptoms that flare at a specific time of day can point directly to which channel is involved.

Channels Is a Bigger Category Than Meridians

A student asked this directly in lecture: 'meridians' specifically means the 12 Primary Meridians, while 'channels' is the whole system - meridians AND collaterals together. When a question says 'channels,' don't assume it only means the 12 primary pathways.

Draw It, Don't Just Read It

Dr. Zhang's own studying advice, repeated multiple times in lecture: draw each circuit's four meridians by hand, more than once, rather than only reading the sequence. This is also the format of the homework assignments for this course.

Same-Named Channels on Opposite Limbs Communicate

Per lecture: arm and leg channels of the same name (e.g., Hand Taiyin LU and Foot Taiyin SP) communicate with one another. A problem in one can sometimes be addressed by treating points on its same-name partner.

The Extraordinary Vessels Are Reservoirs, Not Organs

The 8 Extraordinary Vessels aren't directly linked to a specific Zang-Fu organ the way the 12 Primary Meridians are. They act as reservoirs of Qi and Blood, closely tied to the Kidney, releasing or absorbing as the primary meridians need.

Quiz 1 Fundamentals

Key Terms

- Channel (Jing-Luo) = Meridians + Collaterals (the whole system)
- Meridian (Jing) = one of the 12 Primary pathways - 'like a river'
- Collateral (Luo) = a branch off a meridian's Luo-connecting point - 'like a branch'
- 12 Meridians + 15 Collaterals + 12 Divergent + 12 Sinew + 12 Cutaneous + 8 Extraordinary Vessels = the full channel system

Nomenclature

- 3-part name: Hand/Foot + Yin/Yang + Zang/Fu
- 6 Zang (Yin) organs: Lung, Spleen, Heart, Liver, Kidney, Pericardium
- 6 Fu (Yang) organs: Large Intestine, Stomach, Small Intestine, Bladder, Gallbladder, San Jiao

Circulation

- Yin meridians of the hand: chest -> hand
- Yang meridians of the hand: hand -> head
- Yang meridians of the foot: head -> foot
- Yin meridians of the foot: foot -> chest/abdomen
- Repeat this sequence until automatic - it's the single most tested fact in the course

Circuits

- Outer/Anterior: LU -> LI -> ST -> SP (Taiyin/Yangming)
- Inner/Posterior: HT -> SI -> BL -> KI (Shaoyin/Taiyang)
- Middle: PC -> SJ -> GB -> LR (Jueyin/Shaoyang)

Functions

- Transporting: nourish organs, skin, muscles, tendons, bones; keep Yin-Yang harmony
- Resisting: defend against disease, reflect symptoms when pathogens invade
- Treatment: transmit needling sensation, regulate deficiency/excess

Dr. Zhang's Week 1 homework: draw the circulation, direction, and distribution of the Lung Meridian of Hand-Taiyin specifically - the same drawing standard applies to every meridian going forward.